

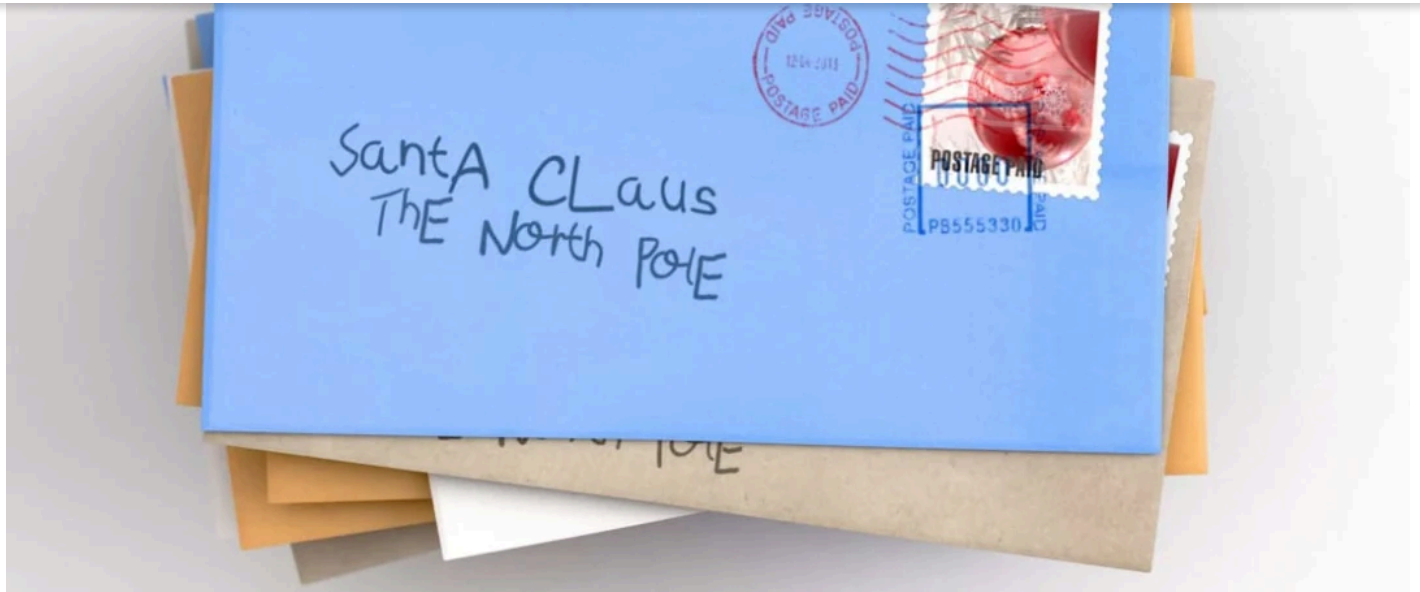


Why Does Santa Claus Live at the North Pole?

By [Ellen Gutoskey](#) | Dec 11, 2019



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As children settle in for a restless night's sleep this Christmas Eve, they'll no doubt be picturing Santa Claus on his way from the snowy 'scapes of the North Pole to deliver them *Star Wars* LEGO sets, *Frozen 2* dolls, and everything else on their wish list. They picture Santa at the North Pole, of course, because they've seen him living there in numerous Christmas movies, books, and television specials, from perennial Rankin/Bass programs to more modern classics like 2003's *Elf*.

While it might seem a little more magical if we told you that nobody really knows why Santa lives there, there is a relatively traceable paper trail: The first known reference to Santa's North Pole residence is in an 1866 cartoon from *Harper's Weekly*.

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According to Smithsonian.com, famed political cartoonist Thomas Nast—who was also responsible for establishing the donkey and elephant as the symbols for the Democratic and Republican parties, respectively—first started creating *Harper's Weekly* Christmas cartoons as Union propaganda for the Civil War in January 1863. Borrowing imagery from Clement Clarke Moore's (alleged) 1823 poem "A Visit From St. Nicholas" (which you'd probably recognize as "Twas the Night Before Christmas"), Nast developed the white-bearded, rosy-cheeked, all-around jolly guy that we know today, and showed him passing out gifts to Union soldiers, climbing into a chimney as a soldier's wife prays, and more.



Thomas Nast, Harris Brisbane Dick Fund, Wikimedia Commons // Public Domain

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inscription along the circular border that reads *Santa Clausville, N.P.* According to *The New York Times*, we don't know exactly why Nast chose the North Pole (or if it was even his own idea), but there are a few reasons it made sense for the time period.

For one, Santa Claus was already widely associated with snow because most of the publishing companies producing Christmas cards and other content were located in New England, where it actually snows around Christmas. Furthermore, the 1840s and 1850s were partly characterized by high-profile—and ill-fated, in the *Franklin expedition's* case—attempts to explore the *Arctic*, and the public was generally interested in the mysterious, poorly-charted region. Because the Pole was unoccupied, Santa and his elves could toil the year away without interference from prying eyes; and, because it was unclaimed, Santa could remain a bastion of benevolence for every nation.

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"Merry Old Santa Claus," perhaps Nast's most famous illustration of Santa, from the January 1, 1881 edition of Harper's Weekly. | Thomas Nast, Wikimedia Commons // Public Domain

Though we'll likely never know Nast's personal rationale behind placing Santa Claus in the North Pole, one thing's for sure: At this point, it's hard to imagine him living anywhere else. It's also hard to imagine him riding a broom, wielding a gun, or smoking cigarettes (find out the stories behind those early Santas [here](#)).

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